



Goliath birdeater

Theraphosa blondi

Regarded as the largest spider in the world, this tarantula has a leg span that could cover a dinner plate, and a mass of about 6 oz (170 g), which far outweighs any of its rivals. Only Asia's giant huntsman spider has a larger leg span. Goliath birdeater females are much larger than the males. The name "birdeater" is based on a 1705 engraving by German naturalist Maria Sibylla Merian, which showed a Goliath birdeater devouring a hummingbird. The tarantula has 1-in- (2-cm-) long fangs, so it may be possible for it to prey on small birds, but its preferred diet is large insects and frogs and mice.

The Goliath birdeater lives in deep burrows on the forest floor and seldom climbs far off the ground. The males only live for three or four years, dying soon after mating for the first and only time, whereas the females can survive for 15 years or more. Each female lays 100–200 eggs and guards the brood constantly for about two months until the spiderlings hatch. If threatened, Goliath birdeaters can flick irritant hairs from their abdomen using their hind legs.

front legs and
pedipalps raised
in threat posture

- ↔ Up to 11 in (28 cm)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🕷️ Insects, frogs, mice
- 🏠 🌳

NE. South
America



◁ DEFENCE STANCE

When threatened, the spider raises up its front legs and shows off its hooked fangs. Defensive bites are "dry," saving venom.

fangs inject
venom

The goliath birdeater detects its prey by **sensing vibrations** in the ground